

Chapter 26

Progress and Its Discontents:

Post-Impressionism, Symbolism, and Art Nouveau, 1880–1905

Learning Objectives

1. Describe the Modernity that emerged in the closing decades of the century, the many complex issues surrounding it, and the broad impact that Modernity had on avant-garde art.
2. Discuss the different ways American and European modern architecture of this period from 1880 to 1906 both broke away from the previously dominant revival styles and also was spiritual, thus sharing some of the concerns of the Postmodernists and Symbolists.
3. Identify the qualities that the Post-Impressionists and Symbolists took from the Impressionists, and the qualities they abandoned or rejected.
4. Explain why fine art photographers were so preoccupied with establishing their medium as a major art form, and how their work reflects the same issues found in painting, sculpture, and architecture of the late nineteenth/early twentieth century.

Modern Life (1)

- The work of Edgar Degas often depicted observances of rehearsals and performance of ballet.
 - *The Rehearsal on Stage* is not a factual record, but a contrivance viewed from the angled perspective of an opera box.
 - Dancers stretch, look bored or exhausted, and are watched over by several "protectors."
- Degas's later images include intimate scenes of bathing women.
 - *The Tub* is rendered from an elevated, domineering vantage point, evidenced by the tipped-up table with a still life of objects associated with bathing.



Edgar Degas THE REHEARSAL ON STAGE

c. 1874. Pastel over brush-and-ink drawing on thin, cream-colored wove paper, laid on bristol board, mounted on canvas, 21-3/8" x 28-3/4" (54.3 x 73 cm).
Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Bequest of Mrs. H. O. Havemeyer Collection, Gift of Horace Havemeyer, 1929 (29.160.26). © 2016.
Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY/Scala, Florence.



Edgar Degas THE TUB

1886. Pastel on cardboard, 23-5/8" x 32-5/8" (60 x 83 cm).

Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Hervé Lewandowski.

Modern Life (2)

- Mary Cassatt was an American expatriate living in Paris who befriended Degas.
 - Her work sought to counteract the clichéd conceptions of the domestic and social life of bourgeois women.
 - *Mother and Child* features contrast between loosely painted clothing and solidly modeled forms of faces and hands.



Mary Cassatt MOTHER AND CHILD
c. 1890. Oil on canvas, 35-1/2" x 25-3/8" (90.2 x 64.5 cm).
Wichita Art Museum, Kansas.

Modern Life (4 of 4)

- Gustave Caillebotte expressed his fascination for the regularized, radiating streets of Paris in *Paris Street, Rainy Day*.
 - This asymmetrical composition and tipped perspective highlights the streets as the subject amidst bustling, anonymous crowds.



Gustave Caillebotte PARIS STREET, RAINY DAY
1877. Oil on canvas, 83-1/2" x 108-3/4" (212.2 x 276.2 cm).
The Art Institute of Chicago. Charles H. and Mary F.S. Worcester Collection (1964.336). Photo © The Art Institute of Chicago.

Japonisme (1 of 2)

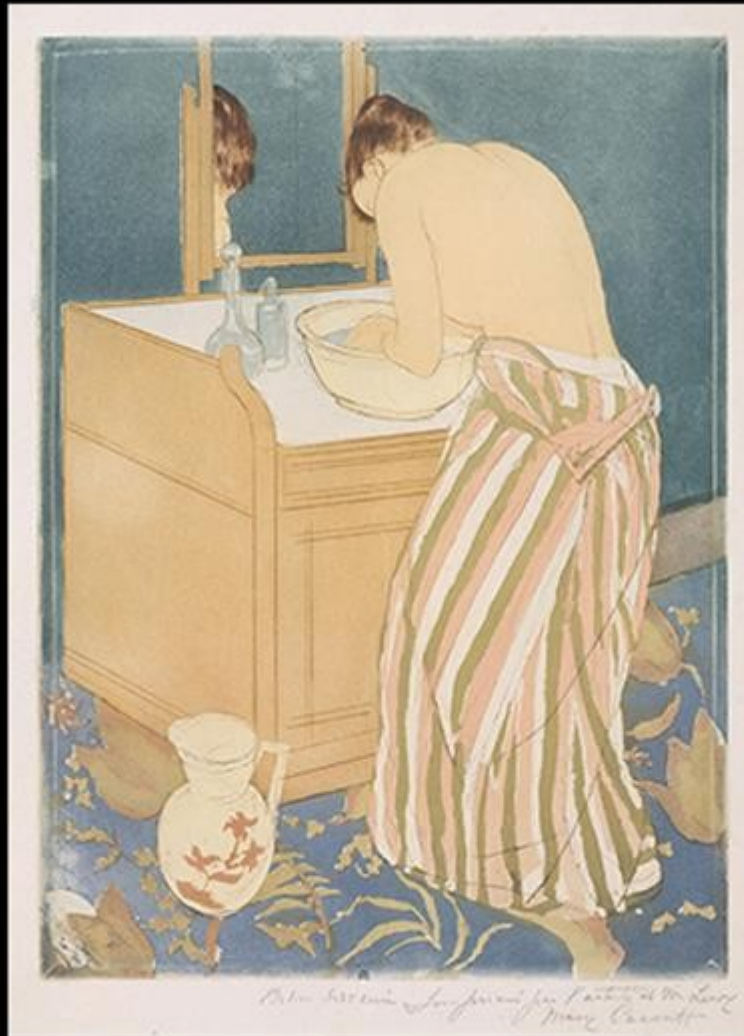
- After the forced reopening of the borders of Japan in 1853, artworks began to be distributed through Paris.
 - Soon, obsession with collecting Japanese objects and art was termed Japonisme.
- Individual Japanese artists worked purely on aesthetic conception rather than Renaissance rules.



Suzuki Harunobu YOUNG WOMAN LOOKING AT A POT OF PINKS
c. 1767. Woodblock print, 10-⁵/₈" × 7-¹/₂" (27 × 19.2 cm).
The Cleveland Museum of Art. Bridgeman Images.

Japonisme (2 of 2)

- Cassatt directly emulated the *ukiyo-e* style, which she had seen at a 1890 exhibition of Japanese woodblock prints.
 - She created ten prints using aquatint and drypoint, and they featured cropped, asymmetrical compositions that would have been seen in Japanese prints.



Mary Cassatt WOMAN BATHING
1890–1891. Color drypoint and aquatint, 16- $\frac{5}{8}$ " × 12" (42.3 × 30.5 cm). National Gallery of Art, Washington, D.C.,
Chester Dale Collection (1963.10.253)
Image courtesy the National Gallery of Art, Washington

The Late Nineteenth Century

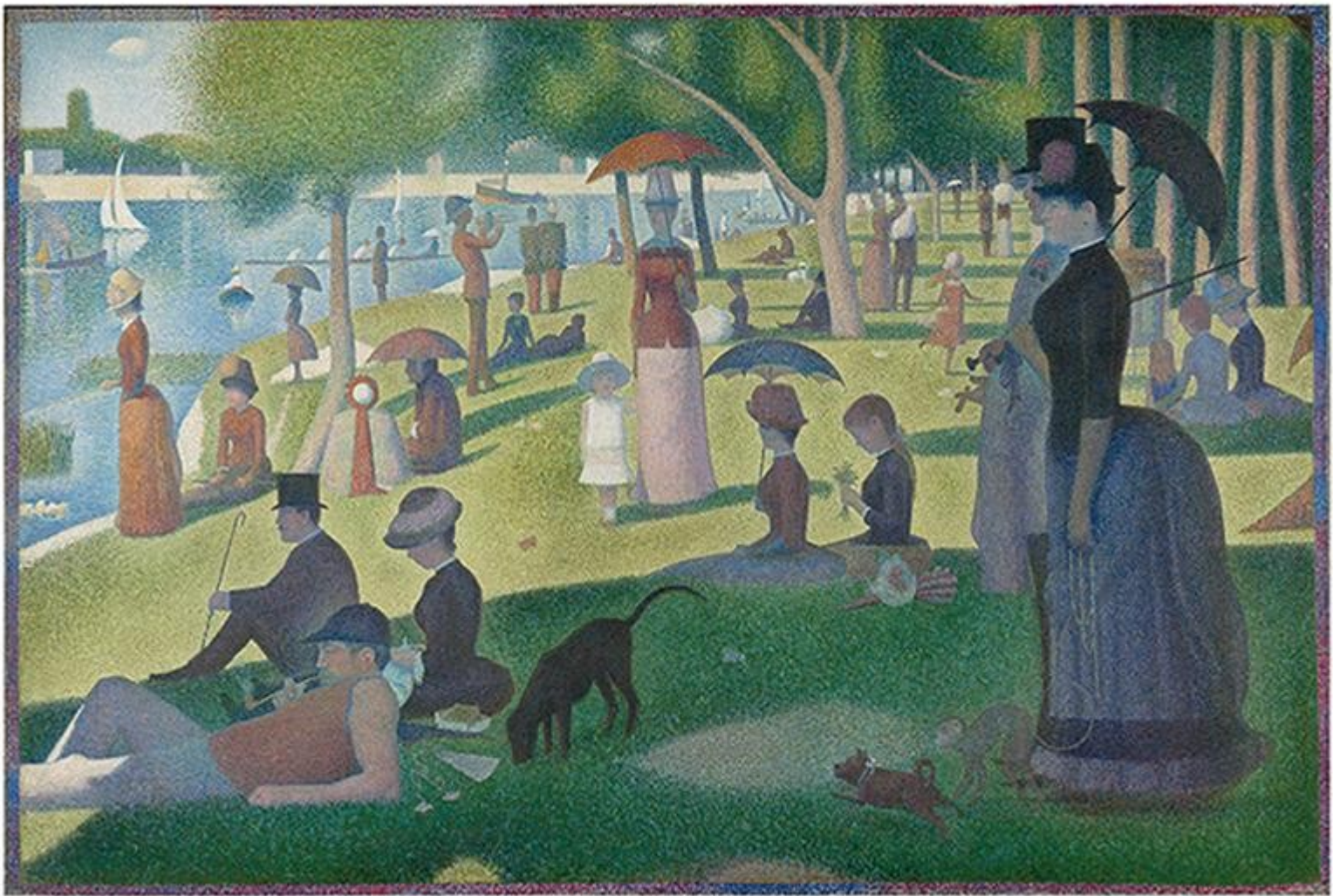
- Artists worked to develop new visual languages for their messages.
- French Post-Impressionists interpreted art as an expression of the imagination.
 - Symbolist artists found a similar retreat in the imagination.
- Art Nouveau artists rejected rational order in favor of whimsical, writhing designs.

Post-Impressionism (1 of 5)

- Critic Roger Fry used this term as a description for a group of artists whose work was not unified, but shared the founding principles of Impressionism from which to adapt.

Post-Impressionism (2 of 5)

- Seurat
 - Georges Seurat (1859–1891) devoted his life to "correcting" shallow aspects of Impressionism.
 - He juxtaposed small strokes of pure, unblended color, creating *pointilism* and the effect of **complementary color** proposed by Chevreul.
 - *Sunday Afternoon...* was painted with 11 colors in three values.



Georges Seurat A SUNDAY AFTERNOON ON THE ISLAND OF LA GRANDE JATTE
1884–1886. Oil on canvas, 6'9-1/2" x 10'1-1/4" (207 x 308 cm).
The Art Institute of Chicago. Helen Birch Bartlett Memorial Collection (1926.22).
Photo © The Art Institute of Chicago.

Post-Impressionism (3 of 5)

- Van Gogh and Gauguin
 - One of the most famous Post-Impressionists, Van Gogh was a socialist who believed that modern life alienated people from both one another and themselves.
 - His contributions to art would lead to the later emergence of Expressionism, art that exaggerates aspects of form to evoke subjective emotion.

Post-Impressionism (4 of 5)

- Van Gogh and Gauguin
 - The artist adapted Seurat's technique, painting in free, multidirectional impasto lines.
 - *The Starry Night* explores his contemplation of life and death with psychological, energetic intensity.



Vincent van Gogh THE STARRY NIGHT
1889. Oil on canvas, 28-3/4 x 36-1/4" (73 x 93 cm).

Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the Lillie P. Bliss Bequest (472.1941). © 2016. Digital Image, The Museum of Modern Art, New York/Scala, Florence.

Post-Impressionism (5 of 5)

- Van Gogh and Gauguin
 - Paul Gauguin created a style he called synthetism, which mixed the observation of a subject with the artist's feelings on that subject.
 - *Mahana no Atua*, painted during his brief return from travels to the South Pacific, depicts an Edenic ideal closer to his imagination than the colonized cultural reality.



A CLOSER LOOK: Mahana no atua (Day of the God) by Paul Gauguin
1894. Oil on canvas. 27-3/8" x 35-5/8" (69.5 x 90.5 cm).
The Art Institute of Chicago. Helen Birch Bartlett Memorial Collection (1926.198).
Photo © The Art Institute of Chicago.

Symbolism (1 of 3)

- This movement addressed the fears, desires, and impulses of the human mind.
- Artists rejected the value of rationalism and utilized strange and ambiguous subject matter in stylized forms.
 - Paintings paralleled a similar movement among poets and writers.

Symbolism (2 of 3)

- Moreau
 - Gustave Moreau rendered *The Apparition* with the macabre head of John the Baptist dripping blood as it hovers in midair.
 - A seductive Salomé drips with decadence in the foreground, symbolizing her role as *femme fatale* who uses her sensuality to destroy a male victim.



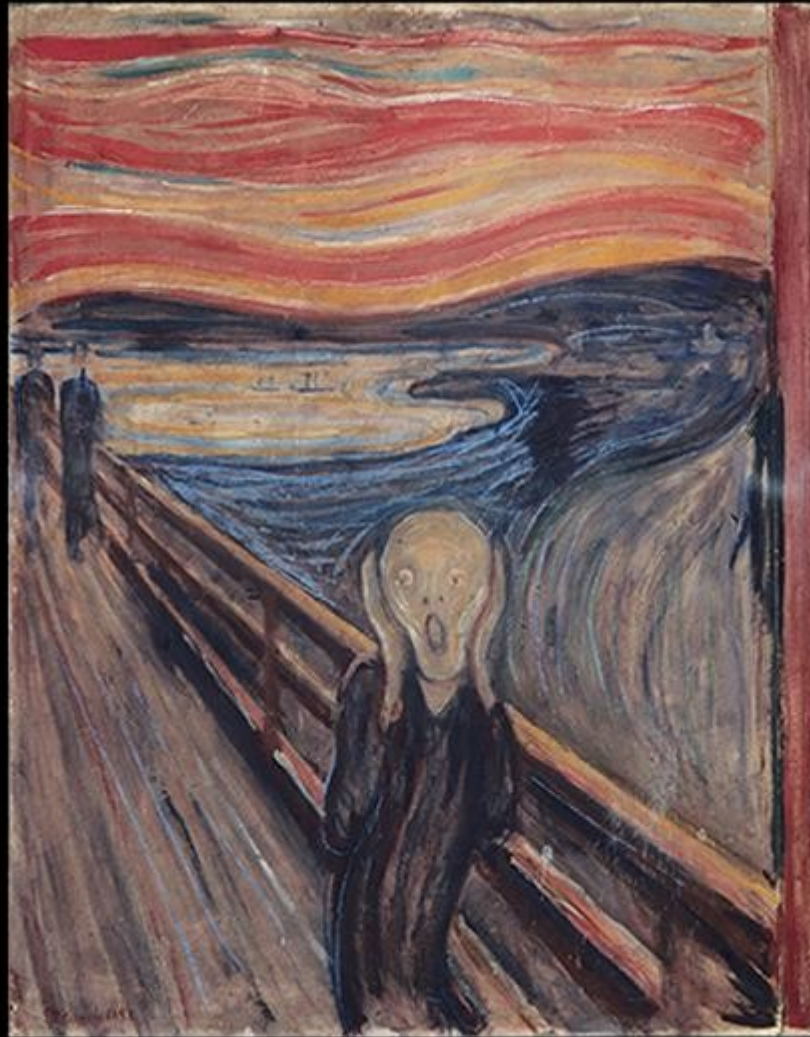
Gustave Moreau THE APPARITION

1874–1876. Watercolor on paper, 41-5/16" × 28-3/16" (106 × 72.2 cm).

Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Jean-Gilles Berizzi.

Symbolism (3 of 3)

- Munch
 - Edvard Munch's *The Scream* depicts a feeling of overwhelming anxiety culminating in a primal scream.
- Ensor
 - A group of agitated people in the foreground of *The Intrigue* are rendered with masks on their faces, giving them a disturbing and menacing quality.



Edvard Munch THE SCREAM
1893. Tempera and oil on unprimed canvas, 33 × 26" (83.5 × 66 cm).
Munch Museum, Oslo. © 2016 Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York. Nasjonalgalleriet, Oslo, Norway/Bridgeman Images.



James Ensor THE INTRIGUE

1890. Oil on canvas, 35-1/2" x 59" (90.3 x 150 cm).

Koninklijk Museum voor Schone Kunsten, Antwerp. © Lukas - Art in Flanders VZW/Photo: Hugo Maertens/Bridgeman Images.

French Sculpture (1 of 2)

- Auguste Rodin (1840–1917) failed to get into the École des Beaux-Arts, leading him to assist other sculptors.
 - He developed a vigorously modeled style, exhibited in the *Burghers of Calais* monument commissioned to commemorate an event from the Hundred Years' War.
 - Critics in Calais were not please with the exaggerated expressions.



Auguste Rodin THE BURGHERS OF CALAIS
1884–1889. Bronze, 6'10-1/2" x 7'11" x 6'6" (2.1 x 2.4 x 2 m).
Hirshhorn Museum and Sculpture Garden, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC. Gift of Joseph H. Hirshhorn, 1966
(66.4340).

French Sculpture (2 of 2)

- Camille Claudel, assistant and later mistress to Rodin, was herself an accomplished sculptor.
 - *The Waltz* is a celebrated sculpture of a dancing couple in the nude.
 - After a government inspector called the nudity indecent, she added a swirling cloth to the woman's lower body.
 - Sinuous poses recall fluid lines of the Art Nouveau.



Camille Claudel THE WALTZ
1892–1905. Bronze, height 9-7/8" (25 cm).
Neue Pinakothek, Munich. Photo © Blauel/Gnamm/ARTOTHEK.

Art Nouveau (1 of 5)

- Literally "new art," the Art Nouveau movement rejected values of modern industrial society.
- Rejecting the functional aesthetic in works such as the Eiffel Tower, artists and architects drew their inspiration from nature and delicate, graceful forms.

Art Nouveau (2 of 5)

- Horta
 - Victor Horta (1861–1947) designed Tassel House with graceful and attenuated curvilinear designs.
 - The use of ironwork, wall decoration, and floor mosaic formed an exquisite and unified whole.



Victor Horta STAIRWAY, TASSEL HOUSE, BRUSSELS
1892–1893. © 2016 – Victor Horta, Bastin & Evrard/DACS, London.

Art Nouveau (3 of 5)

- Gaudí
 - Before Horta's Tassel House, Antoni Gaudí was designing Art Nouveau buildings in Barcelona.
 - Casa Batlló draws on Islamic, Gothic, and Baroque traditions.
 - The façade is a dreamlike fantasy of sandstone sculpture and multicolor glass mosaic.
 - Its roof resembles a recumbent dragon.



Antonio Gaudí CASA BATLLÒ, BARCELONA
43 Passeig de Gracia. 1900–1907.
Vincent Abbey Photography.

Art Nouveau (4 of 5)

- Guimard
 - Hector Guimard is best known for his designs of entrances to the Paris Métro.
 - Much of the rest of his career dealt with interior design and furnishings.
 - *Desk* is asymmetrical and organic.



Hector Guimard DESK
c. 1899 (remodeled after 1909).
Olive wood with ash panels, 28-3/4" x 47-3/4" (73 x 121 cm).
Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Madame Hector Guimard. © 2016. Digital Image, The Museum of Modern Art/Scala, Florence/ Art
Resource, NY.

Art Nouveau (5 of 5)

- Toulouse-Lautrec
 - Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec chronicled life in Montmartre, capturing café dancer *Jane Avril*.
 - Emphasis on outline, tipped-up ground, and integration of blank paper reflect *japonisme* in addition to expressionism.



Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec JANE AVRIL
1893. Four color lithograph, 51-1/8" x 37-3/8" (129.85 x 94.93 cm).
Los Angeles County Museum of Art, Los Angeles. Gift of Mr. and Mrs. Billy Wilder (59.80.15).

The Beginnings of Modernism

- At this time in history, the industrial industry was caught between the classical traditions of the Beaux-Arts style and the new aesthetic.
- Cities like the industrialized Chicago demanded new ways of designing and creating tall buildings.

European Architecture: Technology and Structure (1 of 3)

- A fast-paced life was born of the ability for people to manufacture more, consume more, and travel more.
- There was a growing belief in the perfectibility of society that spawned international fairs celebrating innovations in industry and technology.
- Britain asserted their right to empire at the Great Exhibition in 1851.

European Architecture: Technology and Structure (2 of 3)

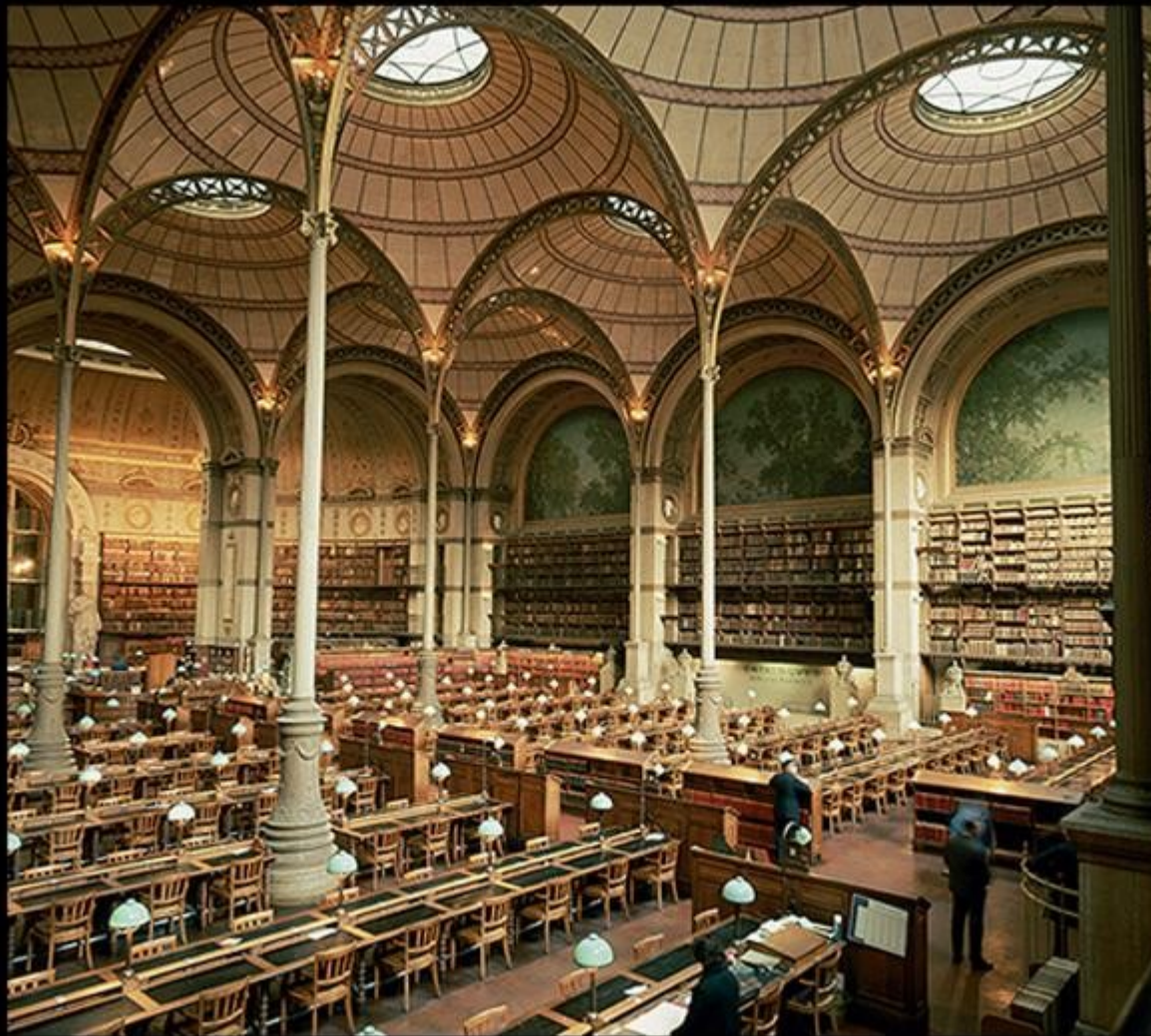
- The Crystal Palace
 - Created by Joseph Paxton, this structure consisted of an cast-iron skeleton holding the largest glass panes that could be mass-produced at the time.
 - The triple-tiered edifice covered over 18 acres, unsurprisingly the largest space ever enclosed up to that time.



Joseph Paxton THE CRYSTAL PALACE
London. 1850–1851. Iron, glass, and wood.
(Print of the Great Exhibition of 1851; printed and published by Dickinson Brothers, London, 1854. Illustration by
Joseph Nash and Robert Haghe). British Library, London.

European Architecture: Technology and Structure (3 of 3)

- Bibliothèque Nationale
 - The Reading Room is an example of the fusion of the academy's historicizing married with technical advances in engineering.
 - Domes faced with white ceramic tiles sat atop thin iron arches and columns that opened up the space.



Henri Labrouste READING ROOM, BIBLIOTHÈQUE NATIONALE, PARIS
1862–1868.
© Paul Almary/Corbis.

The Chicago School (1 of 4)

- The city of Chicago required spaces that would accommodate more people and activities in urban areas.
- It became the center of a new way of thinking about urban design and construction.

The Chicago School (2 of 4)

- World's Columbian Exposition
 - Richard Morris Hunt, an American, began with academy training and supervised the building of this Exposition in 1883.
 - The photograph shows this "White City" in its intended glory—a model city, clean and spacious with Classical planning, in contrast to the conditions found in most American cities.



COURT OF HONOR, WORLD'S COLUMBIAN EXPOSITION, CHICAGO
1893. View from the east.
© Corbis.

The Chicago School (3 of 4)

- Richardson
 - Henry Hobson Richardson created the style of Richardsonian Romanesque, seen in the Marshall Field Wholesale Store.
 - The rough stone facing, arched windows, and decorated cornice evoke architectural antecedents, but with a readily identifiable new style.



Henry Hobson Richardson MARSHALL FIELD WHOLESALE STORE, CHICAGO
1885–1887. Demolished c. 1935.
Courtesy the Library of Congress.

The Chicago School (4 of 4)

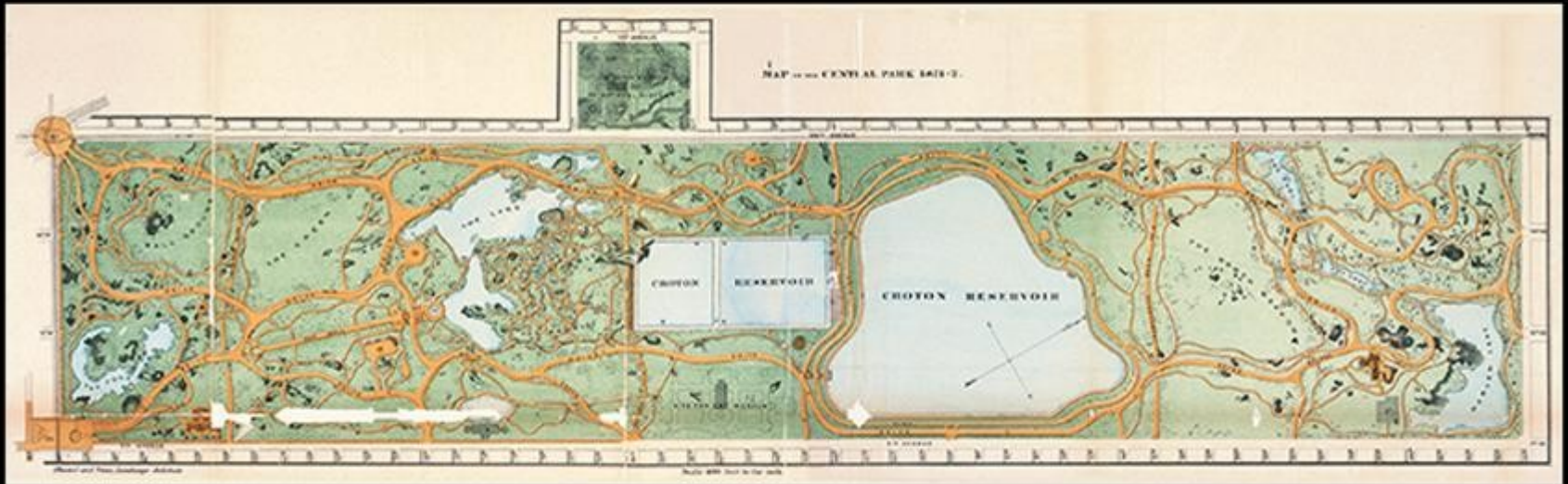
- Sullivan
 - An early example of the Chicago School style is the Wainwright Building in St. Louis, Missouri.
 - This building is taller than it is wide and is comprised of ten stories in three parts.
 - Such a tripartite structure suggests the lingering influence of Classical columns.
 - It illustrates the philosophy of "form follows function."



Louis Sullivan WAINWRIGHT BUILDING, ST. LOUIS
Missouri. 1890–1891.
© Art on File/Corbis.

The City Park

- Crowding and pollution prompted the creation of large public parks between the 1830s–1860s.
- Rapid growth of Manhattan caused civic leaders to set aside parkland while space existed.
 - The resulting Central Park was designed to be the opposite of rectangular and paved-in streets.



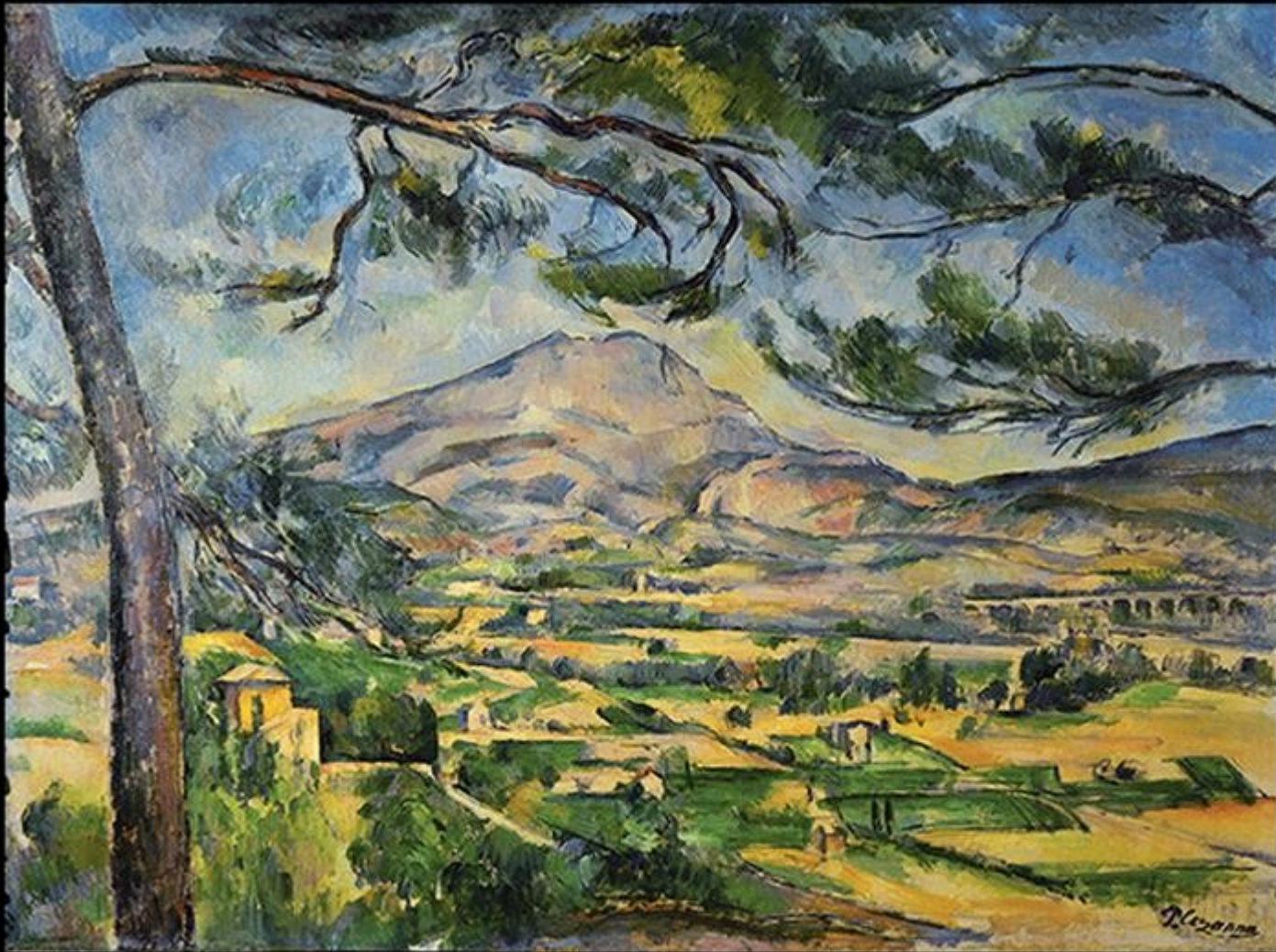
Frederick Law Olmsted and Calvert Vaux MAP OF CENTRAL PARK, NEW YORK CITY
Revised and extended park layout as shown in a map of 1873.
Frederick Law Olmsted & Calvert Vaux/City of New York, Department of Parks

Cézanne (1 of 4)

- Paul Cézanne (1839–1902) adopted a bright palette and loose brushwork to paint his landscapes in the 1870s.
 - These were highly structured and merged drawing and modeling into a single process.
- His goal was to make Impressionism solid and durable, like the art of museums.

Cézanne (2 of 4)

- *Mont Sainte-Victoire* shows a mountain rising above a valley dotted with houses and trees.
 - Its even lighting and absence of human activity create a sense of timelessness.
 - Brushstrokes vary from short cross-hatchings to broad swaths of flat color and are highly deliberate.



Paul Cézanne MONT SAINTE-VICTOIRE
c. 1885–1887. Oil on canvas, 25-1/2" x 32" (64.8 x 92.3 cm).
The Samuel Courtauld Trust, The Courtauld Gallery, London. (P.1934.SC.55). © Samuel Courtauld Trust, The
Courtauld Gallery, London, UK/Bridgeman Images.

Cézanne (3 of 4)

- *Still Life with Basket of Apples* shows spatial ambiguities.
 - The right side of the basket is higher than the left and pastries are tilted up toward the viewer.
 - These shifting viewpoints are not the product of incompetence, but rather a rejection of scientific perspective in favor of positioning objects from multiple sightings.



Paul Cézanne STILL LIFE WITH BASKET OF APPLES
1880–1894. Oil on canvas, 24-7/16" x 31-1/2" (64.8 x 80 cm).
The Art Institute of Chicago. Helen Birch Bartlett Memorial Collection (1926.252).
Photo © The Art Institute of Chicago.

Cézanne (4 of 4)

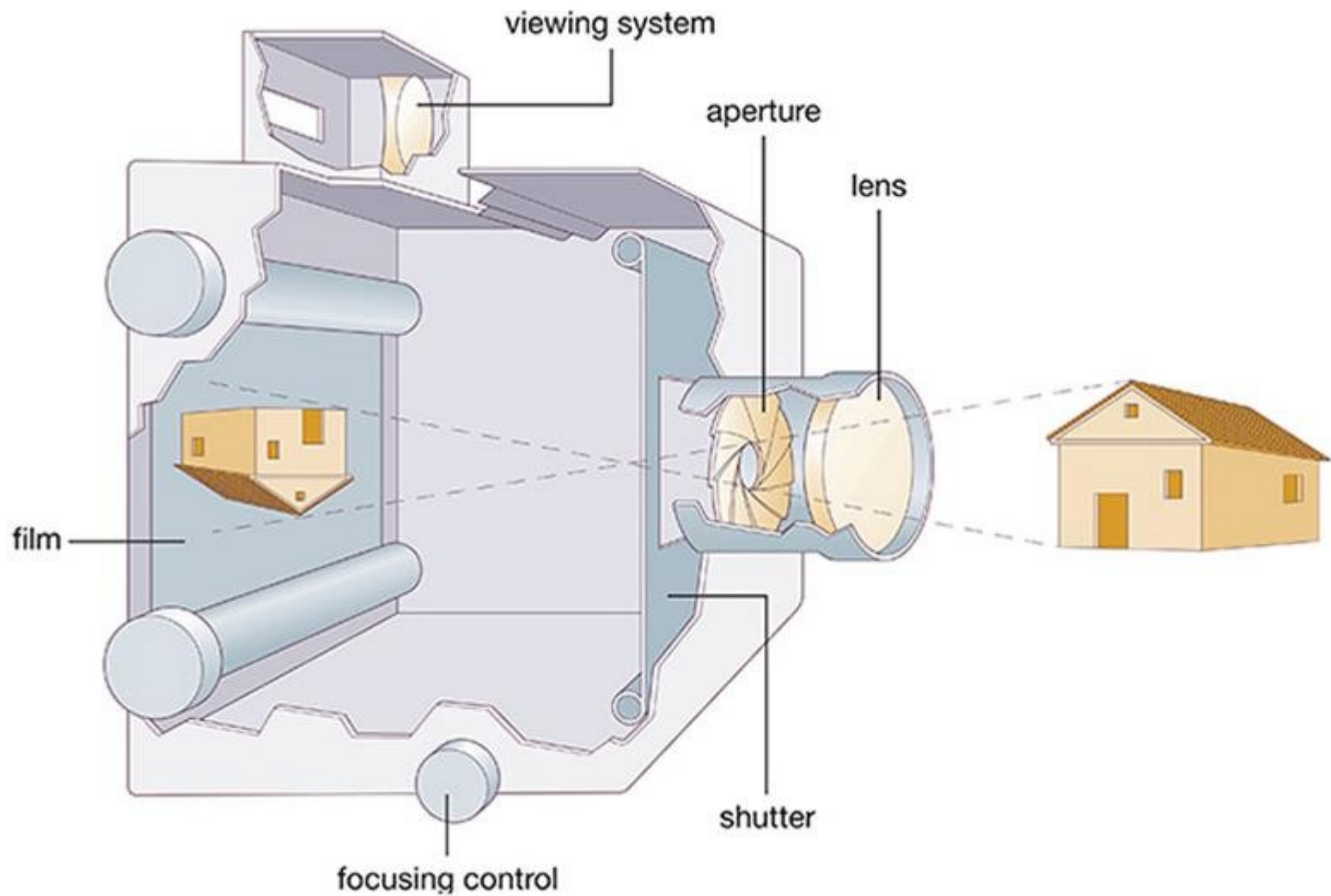
- *The Large Bathers*, left unfinished at the end of the artist's life, was the largest canvas he ever painted.
 - In some ways it returns to certain conventions of history painting; for example, an Arcadian landscape suggesting a mythological theme.



Paul Cézanne THE LARGE BATHERS
1906. Oil on canvas, 6'10" x 8'2" (2.08 x 2.49 m).
Philadelphia Museum of Art. The W.P. Winstach Collection. © 2016. Philadelphia Museum of Art/Art Resource,
NY/Scala, Florence.

Technique: The Photographic Process

- A camera is basically a lightproof box with an aperture, lens, and a shutter.
- When the shutter is open, light reflected off objects strikes the film and exposes it.
- Light is directed through a negative onto paper to create a positive image.
- Today's technology records photo images digitally.



TECHNIQUE: The Photographic Process

Early Photography in Europe and the United States (1 of 4)

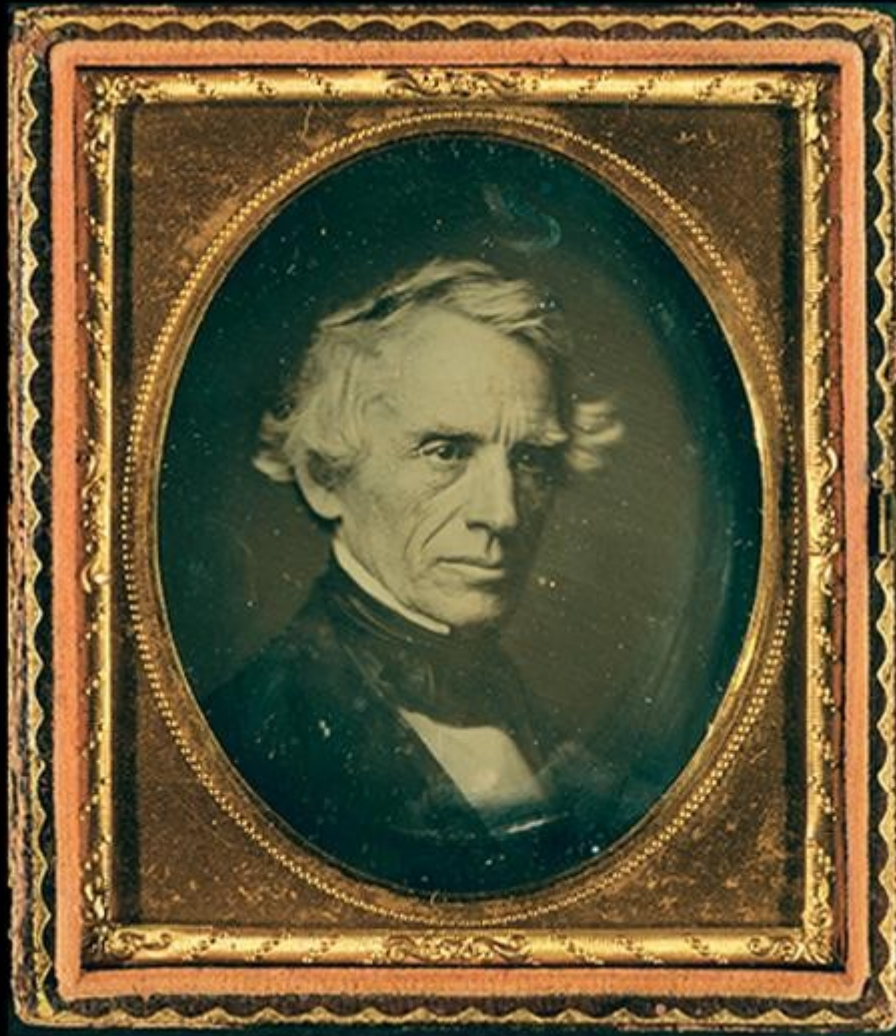
- The *camera obscura* was an early device for recording images from life.
- Photography was developed as a way to make permanent visual impressions.
- Louis-Jacques-Mandé Daguerre was the first to "fix" a photographic image.
 - A silver-coated metal plate treated with iodine fumes could make images visible when treated with mercury vapor.



Louis-Jacques-Mandé Daguerre THE ARTIST'S STUDIO
1837. Daguerreotype, 6-1/2" x 8-1/2" (16.5 x 21.6 cm).
Société Française de Photographie, Paris. © akg-images.

Early Photography in Europe and the United States (2 of 4)

- **Daguerrotypes** include a still life of plaster casts and a framed drawing that stakes a claim for photography as art.
- Samuel Morse, inventor of the telegraph, introduced the daguerrotype to America within weeks of Daguerre's announcement.
 - He reduced exposure times short enough to take portrait photographs.



DAGUERRETYPE OF SAMUEL FINLEY BREESE MORSE

c. 1845. Sixth plate daguerreotype, 2-3/4" x 3-1/4" (7 x 8.3 cm).

The Daguerreotype Collection of the Library of Congress, Washington, DC. Courtesy the Library of Congress.

Early Photography in Europe and the United States (3 of 4)

- William Henry Fox Talbot worked on his own **calotype** independently from Daguerre, making positive prints from negatives, from which an unlimited number of prints could be made.

Early Photography in Europe and the United States (4 of 4)

- Talbot published a book in six parts, *The Pencil of Nature*, which included *The Open Door*.
 - It is a picture evoking an agrarian way of life that was fast disappearing.
- Frederick Scott Archer found that silver nitrate would adhere to glass if mixed with collodion, resulting in a glass negative with greater tonal subtlety.



Henry Fox Talbot THE OPEN DOOR

1843. Salt-paper print from a calotype negative, 5-5/8" × 7-11/16" (14.3 × 19.5 cm). Science Museum, London. Fox Talbot Collection. © National Media Museum/Science & Society Picture Library.

Alexander Gardner and Julia Margaret Cameron (1 of 2)

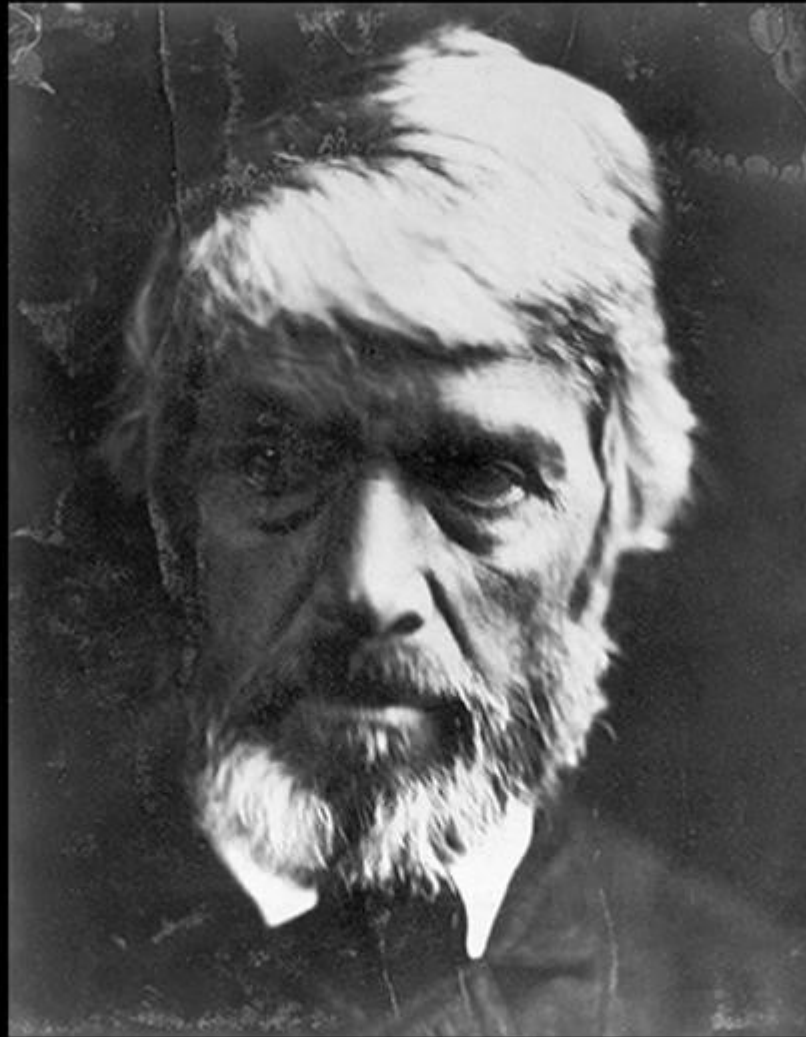
- Alexander Gardner sought to show a *Rebel Sharpshooter* killed in battle, but the image was not organically taken from the Battle of Gettysburg.
 - The photographers dragged the dead body to the site and posed it, exhibiting the difficult reality that photography does not equate to factuality.



Alexander Gardner THE HOME OF THE REBEL SHARPSHOOTER:
BATTLEFIELD AT GETTYSBURG
1863. Albumen print, 7" x 9" (18 x 23 cm).
Library of Congress, Washington, DC. Courtesy the Library of Congress

Alexander Gardner and Julia Margaret Cameron (2 of 2)

- Julia Margaret Cameron began photographing at age 49 and created purposely out-of-focus portraits of great British men.
 - *Thomas Carlyle* calls attention to light that suffused the subject in a metaphor for creative genius.



Julia Margaret Cameron PORTRAIT OF THOMAS CARLYLE
1867. Silver print, 10" x 8" (25.4 x 20.3 cm).

The Royal Photographic Society, Collection at National Museum of Photography, Film, and Television, England. ©
National Media Museum/Science & Society Picture Library